



Ready for any challenge: Nakamura is a formidable presence in classical chess, in which he is ranked third in the world with 2789 points, behind Carlsen and Caruana. LENNART OOTES

Candidates. He won it in 2018 and took on Carlsen for the World championship later that year. After all the 12 games (classical format) were drawn, he lost in the tiebreaker (rapid). Caruana, in fact, had an opportunity to challenge Carlsen in the 2016 World championship as well: he finished second to Sergey Karjakin in the Candidates that year.

Caruana, who became the World No. 2 for the first time in 2014, has been a consistent performer. He has a strong game with no apparent weakness. Carlsen has in fact gone on record saying that he is the world's second-best player.

Nakamura may not be as

consistent as Caruana in classical chess, but he too has been one of the world's top talents for a long time. And he has been a beast in speed chess.

Besides the formats of shorter time controls, he also enjoys playing Fischer random chess, a format in which he won the world title in 2022. He is, of course, a formidable presence in classical chess, in which he is ranked third in the world with 2789 points, behind Carlsen and Caruana.

He had become the World No. 2 in 2015 and a year before that, when FIDE began publishing ratings for the rapid and blitz variations of chess, he was the World No. 1 in both the lists.

Nakamura, who is also a hugely popular streamer, will certainly be one player that all his competitors will be wary of in Toronto. "He has very good chances," says veteran

Indian Grandmaster Pravin Thipsay.

"I feel Caruana has the best game suited to win a tournament like the Candidates, with its double round-robin format. I will be surprised if anybody other than Caruana or Nakamura wins the Candidates this time around. Those two look easily the best players in the field."

If you want to bet on someone other than the talented American duo, there is Nepomniachtchi, who is playing under the flag of FIDE because of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. He has already contested two World title matches (against Carlsen in 2021, and then against Ding last year).

Nepomniachtchi, ranked seventh in the world, is the winner of the last two Candidates tournaments. He won the 2020-21 Candidates tournament, which was disrupted by COVID-19, and then again in 2022,